

COMIC

League of Extraordinary Gentlemen

★★★★☆ | This is one of Alan Moore's overlooked creations. The movie loosely follows the comics, omitting lesser-known characters such as AJ Raffles the gentleman thief, Campion Bond, the grandfather of James Bond and Auguste Dupin, the French precursor to Sherlock Holmes. It also adds entirely new characters, such as Tom Sawyer. Needless to say, the comic is much better, almost at par with Watchmen. There artwork is extraordinary, and the story is, in many ways, reminiscent of Watchmen, including previous versions of the League. The comics are also decidedly and unabashedly full of testosterone, with even a clear disclaimer that says the con-



tent may be offensive to the sensibilities of "lady readers". This is a pretty expansive series with three volumes containing six issues each, a graphic novel called Black Dossier, three "Century" graphic

novels spanning across the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, and a graphic novel trilogy revolving around Nemo. It is only the story of the first volume that the movie loosely tracks, but the story really takes off in the subsequent novels. Everything from the aberrations created by Dr Moreau, to the alien gods of the Cthulhu Mythos, to the Martian Tripods find a way into the series, and it is exhilarating for anyone who likes reading books. There are a whole bunch of easter eggs and pop culture references hidden throughout the pages, and you need to scan the backgrounds carefully to find them. These can be something that could possibly fit into the universe, such as the etching of Arne Saknussemm, to improbable inclusions of characters from Saturday Night Live sketches, and characters that look suspiciously similar to comic book creators such as Jack Kirby or Moore himself. There is a lot to take in apart from the story, even if you do not get the references or know about the vast cast of characters. This was the original Ready Player One.

MOVIE

Joker

★★★★☆ | The line between comedy and tragedy may be as clear as day to the everyday Joe. However, when it comes to Arthur Fleck a.k.a. Joker, portrayed by Joaquin Phoenix, the line begins to blur gradually, until it meshes distinctively into a rope of chaos and laughter. Telling light from dark becomes increasingly tedious as the film progresses and you don't know whether to laugh or cry or scream or just sit mute as the film reaches its stirring climax.

Joker tells the story of a clown who is, ironically, funny only to himself. Arthur really does want to possess a sunny disposition and make everyone laugh, but his aura darkens as he understands the 'comedy' in his life, which is, everyone is laughing AT him. Todd Philip's Joker can be fittingly deemed a miserabilist manifesto since every iota of happiness in the protagonist's life is a lie or a sham.



Phoenix is frighteningly convincing as the Joker, but not the Joker we know and love from the comics or even the films (not looking at you, Suicide Squad). Instead, he plays a hyper-realistic Joker with a solid back-story, something that Heath's Joker never really possessed, and his transformation into the Joker feels valid and understandable, yet so, so wrong. His cackle, which often resembles a hyena, is chilling and Phoenix can switch from delirious laughter to whimpering sobs in a matter of seconds.

The film is controversial, yes. Many claim that it glorifies gun violence and in times like these, especially in the US, you wouldn't be wrong to think that. The film even, perhaps subconsciously, suggests that people with mental illnesses are more likely to turn nihilistic and violent. However, it does bring up important narratives such as a commentary on how society doesn't do a lot to nurture people suffering from mental illnesses.

You'd be wary of the film since every aspect of Fleck's neuro-atypicality is quite vilified and causes the audience to be on guard when he graces the screen. It is seemingly also used as a pretext for his ultimate descent into violence. However, you'll be enraptured by Phoenix's expressions and his grace. Every rejection darkens his face and a simple roll of his shoulder transforms his entire physicality.

The cinematography and mise-en-scène is par excellence as well. Joker utterly bewilders you. You leave the theatre feeling conflicted, since it is a film that delivers the raw reality of agony, rejection and nihilism, but does it in a rather crude manner, which can be difficult to watch.